



**Territorial Fragmentation and International Implications of the  
Myanmar Coup and Civil War**

**Bachelor's Thesis**

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# **Kyaw Bo Bo Tun: Územní fragmentace a mezinárodní důsledky vojenského převratu a občanské války v Myanmaru**

## **ABSTRAKT**

Tato studie zkoumá proměňující se podoby územní kontroly a správy v Myanmaru po vojenském převratu v roce 2021. Po svržení předchozí vlády vypukly v zemi rozsáhlé veřejné demonstrace, které se postupně proměnily v ozbrojený konflikt zahrnující vojenský režim, etnické ozbrojené organizace (EAOs) a Lidové obranné síly (PDFs). Myanmar vstoupil do období narůstající územní fragmentace, v němž centrální stát již nepředstavuje jediného nositele moci a územní kontrola je sdílena, zpochybňována a přetvářena různými starými i novými ozbrojenými aktéry. Studie využívá kvalitativní výzkumný přístup a komparativní případovou studii zaměřenou na čtyři specifické, částečně autonomní regiony: Kachin, Kayin, Rakhine a Sagaing. Tyto regiony byly vybrány proto, že umožňují zachytit různé způsoby územní kontroly a místní správy. Analýza vychází ze sekundárních zdrojů, zejména z odborné literatury a dat organizací, jako jsou ACLED a ISP Myanmar. Výsledky ukazují, že územní kontrola v Myanmaru se výrazně liší napříč jednotlivými lokalitami a má zásadní dopady na společnost, správu i širší politické uspořádání. V Kachinu si centralizovaná etnická ozbrojená organizace udržuje pevnou mocenskou strukturu. V Kayinu vedla současná přítomnost několika ozbrojených skupin k fragmentovanému systému správy. V Rakhinu vybudovala Arakanská armáda velmi silný systém územní kontroly a autonomní správy. V Sagaingu je odpor naopak značně roztříštěný, neboť zde působí mnoho lokálních skupin s omezenou mírou vzájemné koordinace. Studie tvrdí, že konkrétní lokální podmínky zásadně určují způsob výkonu moci. Konflikt v Myanmaru po převratu je komplexní a mnohohvrstevnatý a vykazuje různé úrovně fragmentace, které jsou formovány organizační kapacitou jednotlivých aktérů i místními politickými a bezpečnostními podmínkami. Zatímco v některých regionech lze pozorovat vznik autority připomínající státní správu, jiné oblasti nadále zůstávají nestabilní a konfliktní. Územní kontrola v Myanmaru je proto úzce spojena se způsobem organizace ozbrojených aktérů, což přispívá k hlubšímu porozumění tomu, jak občanské války proměňují mocenské uspořádání státu.

## **KLÍČOVÁ SLOVA**

Myanmar, územní kontrola, územní fragmentace, etnické ozbrojené organizace, Lidové obranné síly, správa na subnacionální úrovni, občanská válka

# **Kyaw Bo Bo Tun: Territorial Fragmentation and International Implications of the Myanmar Coup and Civil War**

## **ABSTRACT**

This study looks into the shifting forms of territorial control and governance in Myanmar after the 2021 military coup. When the previous administration was removed, the nation witnessed many public demonstrations, which turned into a violent struggle involving the military regime, ethnic armed organizations (EAOs), and People's Defence Forces (PDFs). Myanmar has started a time of growing territorial fragmentation because the central state is not the only holder of power, and the country now faces a situation where territorial control is shared by different groups, and reshaped by old and new armed actors. The study uses a qualitative research approach and a comparative case study design that looks at four specific, semi-independent regions: Kachin, Kayin, Rakhine, and Sagaing. These regions were picked because they allow to show various modes of territorial control and local governance. Information for this analysis was gathered from secondary sources such as academic literature and data from organizations like ACLED and ISP Myanmar. The results indicate that territorial control in Myanmar changes greatly from one place to another, with implications for society, governance and more. In Kachin, a centralized ethnic armed organization keeps a firm structure of power. In Kayin, the simultaneous presence of several different armed groups has resulted in a fragmented system of management. In Rakhine, the Arakan Army has built a very strong system for territorial control and independent governance. In Sagaing, the resistance is seen as being very scattered because many local groups are currently at work without much connection. Arguably, the local situation determines how the power is used. This paper states that the conflict in Myanmar after the coup is complex and multifaceted. The situation shows different levels of division, which are caused by the ability of groups and the local reality. While some regions show the start of authority that looks like a state, other locations remain without peace. Territorial control in Myanmar is affected by how these groups organize themselves, all of which helps us understand how civil wars change the power of a country.

## **KEYWORDS**

Myanmar, territorial control, territorial fragmentation, ethnic armed organizations, People's Defence Forces, subnational governance, civil war.

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# 1 INTRODUCTION

The military coup which happened in Myanmar in 2021 changed the country's political and territorial landscape. Because the military removed the elected government at that time, the National League for Democracy (NLD), protests and violent repression occurred nationwide. This chaos later transformed into an armed conflict involving the military regime, ethnic armed organizations (EAOs), and newly formed groups created by people who are against the coup, such as the People's Defence Forces (PDFs) (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023). Following the seizure of power, Myanmar has witnessed the growth of territorial division because the military administration finds difficulty in holding power over many areas. In various locations, groups of armed resistance and EAOs have increased their land power while they build systems of management and rules for governing that stay separate from the central government (Aung, 2025). These situations show the common ways seen in wars within nations where the losing of state power makes paths for groups that are not part of the state to create political rule over the people of the area. Overall, territorial division is widened by the lack of central reach.

Researchers more and more look at these fights through the ideas of territorial control, challenged sovereignty, and rebel rule. These ways of thinking show how wars inside a country often make broken political lands where many different players fight for power across various places (Kirsch & Flint, 2011). In Myanmar, these movements are very clear in the edge areas where groups of ethnic fighters have long built systems for governing that do not depend on the central leadership (Brenner, 2019). The fragmented nature of power is caused by the history of these regions. The fighting in Myanmar carries heavy results for the surrounding region. Millions of citizens have been forced to leave their homes because of the human suffering from the civil war, which makes the nearby nations unstable; groups of nations like ASEAN have tried to fix the problem, but their work has stayed small as the fight is hard to understand and the political power in Myanmar is split into many pieces (International Crisis Group, 2023). This instability is felt by every neighboring country.

This study looks at the current talks among researchers about land splitting and regional-level rule in Myanmar after the 2021 coup. Discussions about the theory of sovereignty and how land is held during civil wars are explored first before the study

looks at the actions of armed groups that are not the state and how rebels govern. Then, Myanmar's ethnic fights and the way EAOs change the shifting political face of the country are focused on by the review. It is often argued that the role of these groups is the foundation of the current change.

This thesis is organized into the following chapters: Chapter 1: Introduction; Chapter 2: Theory and literature review; Chapter 3: Methodology and research approach; Chapter 4: regional comparison; Chapter 5: direct comparison of the four regions; Chapter 6: conclusion; and finally, references. Chapter 2 provides a brief explanation of state sovereignty, the control of territory during civil conflict, and ethnic armed groups in Myanmar. Chapter 3 describes the methodology employed in this thesis, the topic of the research, and the sources of the data. The primary analytical assessment of the four regions, which are Kachin, Kayin, Rakhine, and Sagaing, will be explained in Chapter 4. The selection of these four regions will be discussed in Chapter 3. After a direct comparison of each region in Chapter 5, the thesis will conclude in Chapter 6 with an explanation of all the findings and the discussion of the future of Myanmar.

## **2 THEORY AND LITERATURE REVIEW**

### **2.1 Concept of State Sovereignty**

According to standard understanding, state sovereignty signifies “The governing power that a ruling body holds to manage its land and population.” Some scholars believe that state sovereignty signifies a monopoly regarding the lawful application of strength so that laws can be followed throughout the land (South & Dean, 2018). Usually, control is exercised by a ruling body over the land and its people because the law gives them that right. Numerous modern-day disputes now test this old meaning of state sovereignty. Effective power over specific regions is often lost by the ruling body when internal fighting or social unrest happens. Contested sovereignty occurs when different political groups seek to be recognized as the legal leadership at the same time

(South & Dean, 2018; Kirsch & Flint, 2011). State sovereignty becomes a struggle between groups when the central power fails to provide safety.

Those who study the geography of power suggest that state sovereignty becomes frequently fragmented during times of battle. New power arrangements are generated by the presence of both official and unofficial groups that possess overlapping authority. Crucially, war changes the way land is managed by enabling new ways of ruling (Kirsch & Flint, 2011). Myanmar serves as a very significant instance regarding the problem of contested sovereignty. Various struggles by ethnic groups have been experienced by the nation since it gained freedom in 1948. Researchers suggest that these ethnic groups looked for independence from the central ruling body because they wanted to manage their own affairs (Brenner, 2019). Myanmar became a country where different groups held power in the border areas while the central power remained far away. The military takeover in 2021 made these situations even more difficult by diminishing the legal standing of the ruling body. Governance roles that the central power usually performs were taken by local fighting groups while the movement against the military grew. It is widely thought that the authority of the military leaders was weakened when the opposition started to grow throughout the land (ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute, 2025).

## **2.2 Territorial Control in Civil Wars**

The way civil war functions is heavily influenced by how territorial control is managed. Authority over specific places is sought by fighting groups through more than just physical combat because they want to build power. Territorial control allows groups to find new soldiers and gather wealth since they oversee the daily life of the inhabitants (Brenner, 2019; Kirsch & Flint, 2011). Investigations into civil wars reveal that the splitting of land happens when the central ruling body cannot keep its power everywhere. Rules and systems that work separately from the state are often built by these groups so they can lead the people, and they might include the gathering of money for public use and the creation of safety teams to protect the areas (Kirsch & Flint, 2011). Territorial control is the foundation upon which these groups build their own miniature governments. The long-standing battle within Myanmar clearly shows how these movements work. Small pieces of land have been held by ethnic fighting groups

for a long time, since they provide learning spaces and medical help since the central ruling body does not reach those border regions (Brenner, 2019). Because Myanmar has many ethnic-based regions, territorial control has remained divided for many decades. Significant changes in how territorial control is managed occurred after the 2021 military takeover. Increased resistance was seen in regions like Sagaing and Chin because the opposition groups grew larger. It is reported that older ethnic groups made their power stronger in places where fighting has happened for many years (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023).

### **2.3 Armed Non-State Actors**

Groups that are not part of the government hold a fundamental role in modern civil wars. Resistance groups are often created because people are unhappy or ethnic groups face problems with the rulers. These groups work outside of the official systems while they fight against those in power (Brenner, 2019; South & Dean, 2018). These armed non-state actors exist to challenge the way the country is being led, and the history of Myanmar is marked by the existence of many such groups. Fighting groups were formed shortly after freedom from colonial rule was achieved because people wanted safety and a voice. Many scholars believe that these groups built strong structures and fighting forces to protect their own land in the long run (Brenner, 2019). Myanmar continues to see these groups grow while the political problems of the past remain unsolved. The 2021 coup changed the way the armed fight is built in Myanmar in a significant way. Aside from the groups of EAOs that were already there, fresh groups for resistance, like the People's Defense Forces, appeared throughout the country. These groups show a new kind of spread-out fight against the military rulers (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023). It is asserted by observers that the resistance has moved into a new phase of organization. A new structure is formed by these coalitions.

Numerous EAOs have given help to these new groups for resistance by giving them fighting training, weapons, and materiel, plus help with moving supplies. While this working together has made the fight against the military government stronger, it has also brought hard political situations among different armed groups that have different

political aims (ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute, 2025). It is thought that the future of the nation depends on how these many groups speak to each other. Cooperation is necessitated by the common enemy. Within this situation, systems of rebel governance describe when fighting groups build structures for administration and politics in the lands they hold. These structures appear when armed groups want to make their power strong and keep the people living there on their side (Brenner, 2019). Educational institutions, tax collections, and local management groups are often included in these systems because ethnic armed organizations in Myanmar have used them for a long time (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023). Rebel groups can act as other political powers in war-torn areas. By giving safety and help to the people, legitimacy is gained by these organizations among the civilian populations (Kirsch & Flint, 2011).

## **2.4 Civil war, and the fragmentation of State and Territory**

The process of state fragmentation happens when the power of the central administrative body breaks into different pieces for many fighting actors. This process begins during civil wars when the national office loses the power to keep the whole land under its hand (Kirsch & Flint, 2011; South & Dean, 2018). Overlapping management systems where government and non-state actors use power at the same time usually define these forms of political fragmentation. Such mixed political plans can stay for many years, and they are viewed as semi-stable parts of war areas (Kirsch & Flint, 2011). Today's conflict in Myanmar shows many signs that relate to estate fragmentation. The weakening power of the military group after the takeover made many paths for armed groups to grow their land and their ways of ruling (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023). Internal fights like civil war often change how the land of a country is organized because they give power to different fighting people. Land is often lost by government soldiers in some places while fighting groups get more power in other spots, which makes the way the land is ruled become divided (International Crisis Group, 2023). Territorial fragmentation in Myanmar after the coup shows these things very clearly. People in resistance movements have increased their power across the territory even though the military group keeps its hand heavy on the big towns and

the main roads (ACLED, 2024). Overall, these changes create new maps of power within the nation.

Internal conflicts within nations frequently cause the destruction of central power. Because a single ruler does not hold command across the whole land, various organizations of people fight to gain control over different areas. Territorial fragmentation is created as a social and political journey that changes how leaders govern; it defines long struggles when no side wins a clear battle (Kirsch & Flint, 2011). The weakness of the main ruling authorities to keep power in far lands is a major reason for territorial fragmentation. Non-state actors take over when the state fails to show strength. Although these groups begin as fighters, these groups transform into governing bodies that build systems to rule the groups of inhabitants. These movements build many centers of power inside one nation, which makes old ideas of sovereignty challenged (Brenner, 2019; South & Dean, 2018).

The plans of ruling authorities and rebels determine how territorial fragmentation grows. Warfare specialists often protect larger cities while they leave the small villages where staying is hard. Rural areas are picked by fighters because fighters can hide and find help from local neighbors. This division of land between cities and farms makes the distribution of power uneven, and it is maintained by the competing sides to keep their influence (Brenner, 2019). Land features like tall mountains and thick forests help territorial fragmentation to happen. Geography gives fighters ways to hide from soldiers so they can keep their zones safe. Central ruling authorities find that moving power into places with no roads is hard. It is often argued that geography chooses the locations where power is fragmented (Kirsch & Flint, 2011). Because nature creates these borders, the state cannot easily reach the edges. The time that a conflict lasts changes how much territorial fragmentation exists. While short battles cause small breaks, long struggles make territorial fragmentation stay forever. Governance structures and trade and money systems are built by non-state actors inside the lands they rule. Many researchers say that these groups gain political trust from the groups of inhabitants over many years. This situation allows different leaders to live together inside one country where the fighting has lasted so long (South & Dean, 2018).

## **2.5 Myanmar: EAOs and Armed Groups and State Integrity**

Across the world, Myanmar has seen one of the longest internal wars in history. The history of Ethnic conflict has continued since the country became free because of fights over self-determination, seats in politics, and how to share natural resources (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023). It is stated by researchers that ethnic armed organizations have kept their strong places in the edge regions where they built ruling systems and soldier groups (Brenner, 2019). These groups may not stop until their goals are met and their lands are safe. EAOs and Armed Groups stay as the main actors in the war landscape of Myanmar. A large number of these groups have great soldier power, and they keep their rule for a long time in the border lands (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023). Following the 2021 coup, some EAOs have worked with the fighting people who follow the National Unity Government. The balance of power is changed by these alliances because they make the size of the fight against the military rulers much larger (Aung, 2025). These unions might be the only way to challenge the ruling center. Division of land power in Myanmar brings many important questions about how the political system of the country will be in the future. Crucially, giving more freedom to the ethnic lands could bring a federal political plan (International Crisis Group, 2023). Other people warn that the fighting which goes on can lead to long-term political breaking and different ruling powers across the whole country (Kirsch & Flint, 2011). State Integrity is threatened when the center cannot hold the pieces of the nation together.

## **2.6 Research Gap**

Research on the political trouble of Myanmar has grown since the 2021 coup, but only a few papers look simultaneously at the dynamics of territorial control and the fragmentation of ruling authority. Older writings mostly talk about why the coup happened or the sad fate of the local people (Aung, 2025). The current thesis tries to fill this empty space by looking at how Territorial authority moved in Myanmar after the coup. Examining the part that EAOs and resistance groups play when they build ruling ways in the small regions is also done in this work. Crucially, governance fragmentation is being studied through these shifting maps of control.

### **3 METHODOLOGY AND RESEARCH APPROACH**

The current academic investigation utilizes a qualitative research approach to look at the shifting shapes of territorial control and governance in Myanmar after the 2021 military coup. Because the academic investigation concentrates on difficult political and social sequences of events, a qualitative method is suitable. These sequences of events involve the actions of armed participants and the gradual creation of local governance structures. The transformation of sovereignty at the subnational level is also examined through this method. Numerical data is not used so that an analytical examination of conflict dynamics and regional variation can be finished in a deep way. This academic investigation follows ideas from writings on civil wars, which include territorial fragmentation, contested sovereignty, and what non-state armed participants do. These theoretical views give a path for looking at how authority is used across different geographical areas and how local participants act when the central state becomes weak.

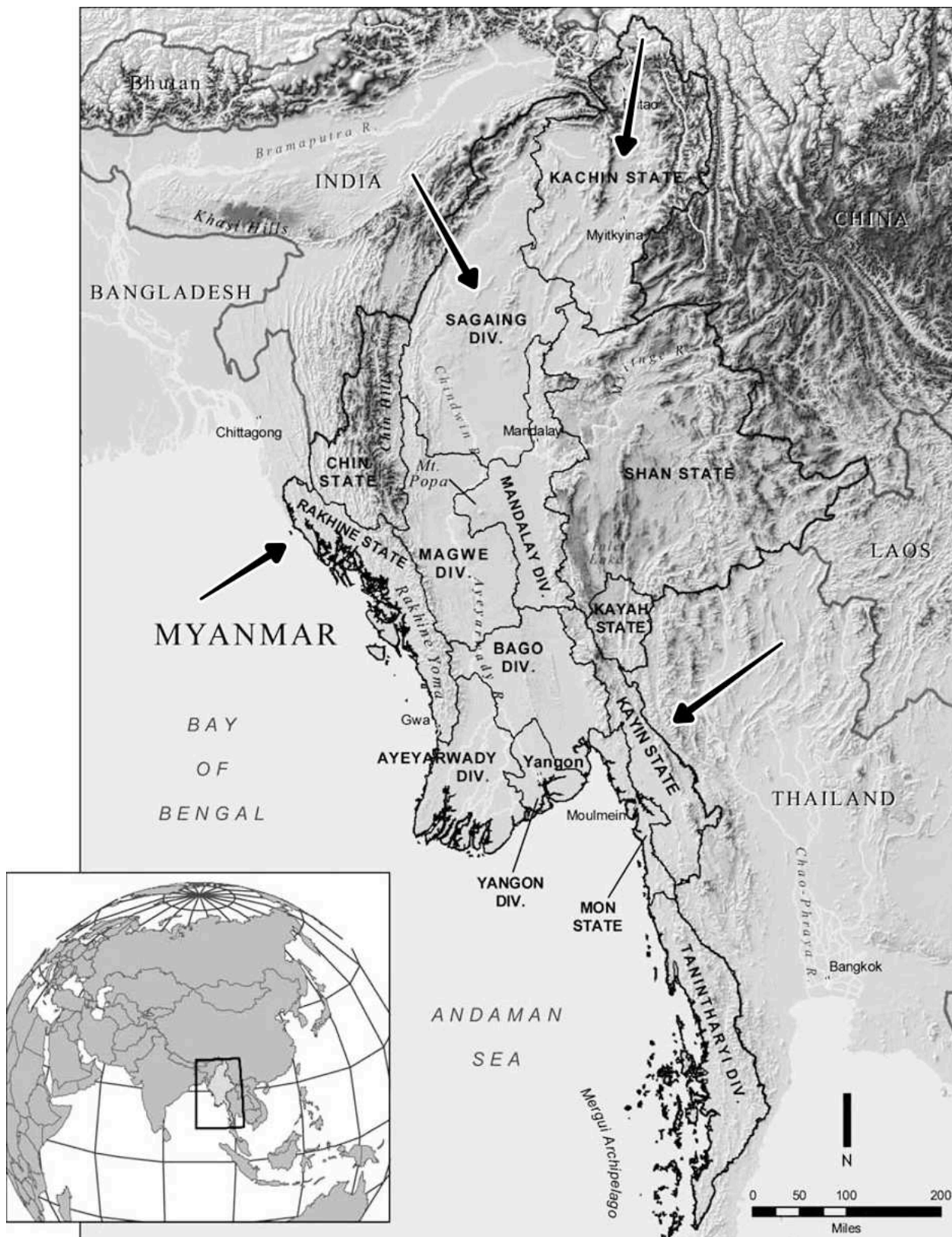
A comparative case study design is utilized by this academic investigation, which looks closely at four geographical areas of Myanmar: Kachin, Kayin, Rakhine, and Sagaing. These geographical areas were chosen because they show different shapes of conflict, territorial control, and governance, allowing for a useful comparison. Kachin shows a situation where ethnic armed organization control is centralized, and long-standing institutions build territorial authority. Kayin has a fragmented environment where many armed groups and changing alliances exist. While Rakhine shows strong territorial control under one main non-state participant, Sagaing shows a resistance model that is spread out among many local groups. By looking at these geographical areas together, the academic investigation finds how territorial control is built and kept. The analytical examination becomes stronger when findings are checked across many situations instead of just one case.

Regarding data collection, secondary sources form the main basis for this analytical examination, including academic literature, policy reports, and conflict datasets. Reports from organizations like ACLED, ISP Myanmar, Myanmar Peace Monitor, and Myanmar Witness are used because these organizations provide data

pieces on conflict events, territorial control, and the work of armed groups. Academic books and journal articles help provide theoretical context and historical background. These data pieces help place current events within the long patterns of conflict and state formation in Myanmar. To make the work more reliable, data pieces from different regions were compared and checked against each other. Since the situation in Myanmar changes very fast, using many kinds of sources allows for a balanced and modern analytical examination.

A thematic analytical framework is applied to this academic investigation based on the research questions. The analytical examination concentrates on main parts like territorial control, what armed participants do, governance at the subnational level, and the results for territorial integrity. Each regional case study uses the same structure so that a systematic comparison across geographical areas can be done. Territorial control is looked at by checking stability and where it is located, and the work of armed participants can be understood through their structures and plans. Governance is measured by looking at the administrative systems and local authority. Results for territorial integrity are thought about in relation to larger political results. This framework makes sure the work is the same and allows for a clear comparison in the later parts of the thesis.

Several limitations exist for this academic investigation. Because the analytical examination uses secondary sources, the work depends on how much data is available and if that data is correct. Even though an effort was made to use good sources, some data pieces might not be full or might have bias, since the situation in Myanmar is very active, and the things happening on the ground can change fast. Findings show a specific time instead of a long-term situation. Even though the focus on four geographical areas does not show the whole conflict landscape of Myanmar, this academic investigation still helps people understand the patterns of territorial fragmentation. Finally, artificial intelligence tools, including *Grammarly* and *NotebookLM*, were used in a small way to improve the writing, fixing grammar, making the language clear and putting notes in order. The analytical examination, data interpretation, and argument creation were done only by the author. The final version of the thesis shows the critical thinking and the academic work of the author.



Picture: Map of Myanmar showing selected case study regions (Kachin, Kayin, Rakhine, Sagaing).

Source: ResearchGate (n.d.).

As the map above illustrates, Myanmar is a nation with an administrative structure organized along 14 regions. It is made up of seven states and seven regions, with Naypyidaw serving as the nation's capital and seat of government. (World Bank, 2023). The Bamar ethnic majority resides in areas like Ayeyarwady, Bago, Magway, Sagaing, Tanintharyi, and Yangon. Additionally, the other major ethnic minority groups reside in states like Kayah, Kayin, Chin, Mon, Rakhine, and Shan, demonstrating the ethnic variety of the nation. Each of these entities is run by a subnational administrative structure headed by a chief minister chosen by the federal government, with assistance from state or regional governments in charge of local planning, administration, and service provision. Because of the existence of resistance groups and ethnic armed organizations, power is still disputed in many areas despite this legal structure. Because of this, non-state actors and state institutions frequently share administrative control. In this context, the Kachin Independence group, which has long-standing administration systems, is an example of a relatively centralized ethnic armed group. Several armed factions, such as the Karen National Union and local resistance forces, compete and work together to shape territorial authority in Kayin, reflecting a fractured combat context. The Arakan Army has established parallel government structures and solidified territorial supremacy in Rakhine, which serves as an example of growing quasi-state power. Sagaing is an example of a highly decentralized resistance model in which a large number of locally organized People's Defence Forces establish erratic and flexible patterns of territorial control.

## **4 REGIONAL COMPARISON**

### **4.1 Kachin**

#### **4.1.1 Background of the Region**

Northern Myanmar contains Kachin State which sits near the China border and remains a land of heavy importance and fighting area. This area is mostly home for the Kachin ethnic group and has been a theater of fighting against the central leadership for a long time. Since Myanmar gained its independence 1948, many groups in far lands started fighting, but the Kachin Independence Organization (KIO) and the Kachin Independence Army (KIA) had much power to change how politics and land are controlled (Brenner, 2019; South & Dean, 2018). Territorial control was influenced by the KIA in this northern region.

Early in the 1960s, the Kachin Independence Organization (KIO) started because people felt ignored and wanted to be more engaged in the running of state. As time passed, the Kachin Independence Organization (KIO) created military strength and also good ways to manage and lead people so that the Kachin Independence Organization (KIO) could rule the land of the Kachin Independence Organization (KIO). Money is taken from the people through these leading systems, and educational institutions for learning, medical help, and small local offices were built, which work away from the central government (Brenner, 2019; Aung, 2025). Arguably, the Kachin Independence Organization (KIO) created a strong way of living. A situation of two systems was created by different leaders in Kachin State so that authority is used by state and non-state actors in different areas (South & Dean, 2018). When the peace agreement ceased in 2011, a new time of fighting began between the KIA and the Myanmar soldiers. Once this fighting occurred, the control of the land broke into pieces, and the Kachin Independence Organization (KIO) assumed stronger political leadership. These old patterns of fighting and leading are the necessary knowledge for understanding what happened after the 2021 coup. Strong institutional bases were built by the Kachin Independence Organization (KIO) before the new war started (Brenner, 2019; Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023).

#### **4.1.2 Territorial Control After the 2021 Coup**

After the 2021 military coup, the way land is controlled in Kachin State changed because the central power became weak and the ethnic groups grew. Subsequent to that coup, the KIA engaged in more fighting against the soldiers while the KIA hit military bases and roads for moving things. The territorial influence was expanded by the KIA, especially in rural areas where the state was not present (ACLED, 2024; Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023). The 2021 coup gave a chance for the KIA to grow, as during this same time, the soldiers kept the power of the soldiers in big cities like Myitkyina and on important roads and offices. A fragmented landscape was produced by this division where the state and other groups each have the pieces of land belonging to these groups. Instead of having clear lines for the fight, Kachin State has areas where power moves and the fighting never stops (ACLED, 2024; ISP Myanmar, 2024). Overall, these areas are very unstable, and information about the fighting shows that there were many more clashes between the KIA and the military after the coup started. The dynamic nature of the war was shown by the data because territorial control moves and changes when military power and politics change (ACLED, 2024; Kirsch & Flint, 2011). At this time, the violence in Kachin State has been worsening, and the growth of KIA territorial control matches the national trend where groups take land once the center is weak. The patterns of dominance were reinforced by the KIA during this time, making Kachin State a region where the breaking of political power has helped the groups who fight to keep their land (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023; ISP Myanmar, 2024).

Geography influences the management of territory within Kachin State. The region is dominated by high mountain ranges. High mountains and the land near the China border help the KIA by giving the KIA strength to move easily. Strategic spots are created where the military cannot enter when the KIA stays in these mountains, making the conflict hard to end. The 2021 coup changed things, but geography still controls how territory is managed (Brenner, 2019; ISP Myanmar, 2024). Actions at the border help the KIA stay strong through the wealth from the unofficial trade that commonly happens near the China–Myanmar border and money is provided by this trade so the KIA can lead and fight. These economic movements are why the groups do not fail. Even though some people do not talk about this trade, the trade helps the

non-state actors keep their authority for a long time (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023).

#### **4.1.3 Role of EAOs and PDFs**

Armed groups of people from different ethnic regions change how the fighting happens in Kachin State. Since the 2021 coup happened, the KIA became the strongest actor in the area. The KIA is better than the new groups because it has much military knowledge and old bases, with a very strong position against the military regime (Brenner, 2019). Groups called People's Defence Forces (PDFs) started working with the KIA after the coup ended the old ways. Because the KIA wants to fight the junta, it provides both teaching and guns. The fighting across Myanmar grew when the KIA helped these groups with many items, and recently the old ethnic wars joined with the new fight for democracy (ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute, 2025; Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023). Unity is not always found between the EAOs and the PDFs even though they fight together. The PDFs want to bring back democracy while the KIA wants self-rule for ethnic people. Because the KIA wants federalism and long control of the land, it has different goals than the PDF, causing problems for the plan of the fighting (ISP Myanmar, 2024; Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023).

Support for the major resistance started in Kachin State because the KIA is an old group with much ruling experience. Sagaing is a region where PDFs work alone, but the KIA leads everyone in Kachin State. A model of working together is created in this region, and its old history is why the resistance works so well. The strength of the result of the groups depends upon consolidated power (ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute, 2025). Knowledge of how to fight moves from the KIA to the new PDFs when they work together. Teaching and the ways of the military are given to the PDFs by the KIA through its prolonged role in fighting, this help makes them ready very fast, and the anti-junta forces become better at fighting because the KIA shares its secrets (ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute, 2025; ISP Myanmar, 2024). Future politics is influenced by the KIA of its current leadership in fighting. The KIA is not just a group with guns but a group that makes decisions for the country, and which will potentially change how

Myanmar is built after the war. As a credible political actor, it discusses the future of all the people (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023).

#### **4.1.4 Governance and Sovereignty at the Subnational Level**

A distinct situation exists in Kachin State where governance and sovereignty are being shaped again within fighting environments. Because the KIO manages administrative methods that act as substitutes for official state bodies, taxation mechanisms and judicial structures are maintained alongside public service provision (Aung, 2025; Brenner, 2019). These governance structures allow the KIO to show real power over residents while keeping political legitimacy. After the military takeover in 2021 happened, these governance systems grew larger as the power of the central authorities became fragile. In various locations, the KIO functions as a side-by-side state when the KIO provides educational institution instruction and medical professional help independently of the military rulers. This situation broadly exemplifies rebel governance, where individuals or groups who are not the state take over duties usually linked with the government (Aung, 2025; South & Dean, 2018).

The simultaneous presence of many governance systems in Kachin State fits within the idea of contested sovereignty. Since authority is not held in one center by the state, power is split between different groups that compete, resulting in a mixed political order, defined by institutions that cross over each other and different groups that say they are the true leaders (Brenner, 2019; ISP Myanmar, 2024). The link connecting territorial control with governance is seen very clearly in Kachin. When the KIA grows its influence over the land, the KIO is able to stretch its administrative work, which makes its status as a political authority stronger. Military strength and governance capacity are tied together tightly during civil wars (Kirsch & Flint, 2011). When military control increases, administrative power follows.

One more part of governance in Kachin State is how legitimacy and the giving of services relate to each other. Legitimacy is gained among local people when the KIO provides social benefits like educational institutions and medical professional services. Accordingly, the military government loses its power in contested areas because the military uses force instead of helping the people. This difference makes the KIO seem

like a better governing group in specific areas (Aung, 2025; South & Dean, 2018). Governance patterns are uneven, changing based on how much control exists and how strong the fighting is. While the KIO has powerful administrative control in some areas, governance in other spots stays fractured and argued over. This uneven spread of governance capacity shows the complicated nature of land breaking apart during civil wars (ISP Myanmar, 2024).

#### **4.1.5 Implications for Territorial Integrity**

Strong effects on the future integrity of Myanmar are expected from the events happening in Kachin State. Because the KIA is growing its territorial control and governance capacity, a movement toward more self-rule at the local level is suggested. This change might help a federal political system start where ethnic areas have more power even though they stay inside one united country (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023; Aung, 2025). The continuation of war and uneven territorial control brings the chance of lasting trouble. If the groups that compete keep building their own power in different areas, Myanmar might change into a very spread-out system where many centers of power exist instead of one strong federal state. Such breaking apart can hurt the work done to make the nation one and keep political stability (ISP Myanmar, 2024; South & Dean, 2018).

These patterns show the pull between making a federal system and the breaking of the country as paths for what Myanmar will become. A way to end the fight is offered by federalism, but a long and shaky political time might happen if the land continues to break apart. Much of the future depends on which of these paths wins. Serious consequences for Kachin State arise from the possibility that fragmented administrative structures might become permanent. Because non-state groups manage geographic areas and provide help to the people, these arrangements may be made solid by the passing of time. This makes returning to a central power very difficult even when peace talks occur, so that fragmentation might last much longer than the time of the war (Kirsch & Flint, 2011). Looking at the past helps people understand how Kachin State faces current struggles. The strength of non-state leadership is shown by the KIO because the KIO has lived as a ruling actor for a very long time, with current events

representing a stronger version of old trends rather than a brand-new change. This long history helps non-state administration ways to stay strong while the KIO changes to fit new political climates (Brenner, 2019; Aung, 2025).

#### **4.1.6 Regional Summary**

Evidence shows how the 2021 coup forced existing fragmented state patterns and argued ownership to move faster in Myanmar. The power of ethnic armed groups is expanded through the growth of KIA territorial control while the KIA works with other fighting groups. Different political leaders are appearing at local levels because the KIO is building new administration ways. History reveals that Kachin State is a region where old rebel systems have changed to fit new political times. The fractured nature of state power is made clear by these changes, and Kachin State gives a clear window into the future paths that the political system of Myanmar might take.

### **4.2 Kayin**

#### **4.2.1 Background of the Region**

Situated in the southeast part of Myanmar near the border with Thailand is the area of Kayin State (also known as Karen State, after the name of the main ethnic group). This land has witnessed one of the longest armed struggles in the world, since this region has been the center of very long fights against the government. Since Myanmar gained freedom in 1948, the Karen National Union (KNU) and the Karen National Liberation Army (KNLA) have been major players that fight the central power, seeking more self-rule and a federal system (Brenner, 2019; South & Dean, 2018). Starting in 1947, the Karen National Union (KNU) grew to be a very large ethnic armed group in Myanmar. Its administrative institutions and political bodies were developed alongside its soldiers, which is different from how some other groups work, but has also allowed the Karen National Union (KNU) to manage lands that stay under their hand. Because of it, learning systems, medical care, and tax collection have been established in the countryside locations near the Thai-Myanmar border (Brenner, 2019).

In comparison with Kachin State, power remains solidly under the control of the KIO, but the Karen National Union (KNU) is divided into different groups and brigades. Varying amounts of self-control are used by different brigades of (KNU) in this area, and these internal splits have decided how the land and politics work in Kayin State. This division makes the power in Kayin State feel like water that moves and changes often (South & Dean, 2018). After the peace talk agreement in 2012, fighting in Kayin State stopped for a short time and some places became calm. Renewed violence and trouble were brought back by the 2021 military coup which changed the direction of the region, with the old fighting groups in Kayin State giving the base for new resistance growth against the junta. While the resistance became strong again, the splits inside Kayin State made the fight much harder to understand than the fight in Kachin (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023).

#### **4.2.2 Territorial Control After the 2021 Coup**

Changes in territorial control in Kayin State happened because the 2021 military coup started the guns firing again between the soldiers and the ethnic forces. Military operations against the junta were restarted by the (KNU) after the coup, especially in the lands where the brigades have power. The areas where fighting happens have grown larger, even if they still happen most in the countryside locations and border lands where the central power has always been weak (ACLED, 2024; Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024). Comparing this to Kachin State shows that the territorial control in Kayin State is fragmented into many small pieces and is not held by one center. Different levels of power are held by various (KNU) brigades across the whole area while some spots stay as fighting ground between the junta and the resistance. Meanwhile, the military still holds the major towns and the roads for moving things. Even though the military has the towns, the people who resist hold a majority of the countryside, which makes a map where powers overlap and cross (ACLED, 2024; ISP Myanmar, 2024; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024).

Numbers about the fighting show an important rise in the deployment of bombs from planes and soldier movements in Kayin State after the coup happened. Widespread movement of people and lack of safety for the regular residents were caused by this

fighting in Kayin State (ACLED, 2024; Karen Human Rights Group, 2021; 2023). Regular residents must walk between many different armed groups because the power is always moving and the safety is low (Karen Human Rights Group, 2023). The physical shape of the land is a very important reason why the power moves this way in Kayin State. Strategic benefits are given to the resistance forces by the tall mountains and the land being near the Thai border. These mountains help the fighters move fast and hide from the soldiers. Accordingly, the fighting has lived in Kayin State for a long time and still decides territorial control today (Brenner, 2019; ISP Myanmar, 2024). Significantly, military tactics and the movement of local residents connect with each other. Because armed activities like attacks from the sky and assaults on rural settlements occur, many local residents are forced to flee their residences, especially in rural areas where fighting happens. This movement of people reflects insecurity, and this movement of people reshapes territorial control when the land becomes empty, which reduces the possibility for any group to create a steady administration (Karen Human Rights Group, 2021; 2023; ACLED, 2024). The existence of various fighting factions that function together inside the same land affects territorial control in Kayin State. Power of command is often negotiated through informal ways between separate factions because there is no single center of rule. These temporary agreements make the fight fragmentary, which makes naming specific regions where one group holds power a hard task (ISP Myanmar, 2024; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024).

#### **4.2.3 Role of EAOs and PDFs**

The ethnic armed organizations, specifically the KNU and its fighting wing the KNLA, stay at the heart of the fighting situation in Kayin State. There, the KNU functions as a primary force in the resistance against the ruling military since the year 2021. Military support and land bases are provided by the KNU so that opposition groups can have a place to stay (ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute, 2025; Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024). Because the KNU works together with the newly created People's Defence Forces, the strength of the resistance grows while the fighting in the southeast of Myanmar increases. Instructions for fighting and supplies are given to the PDFs by the KNU to help their joint efforts. The

coordination of these groups is hard when strategic objectives are not the same and the KNU has internal disagreements (ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute, 2025; ISP Myanmar, 2024; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024).

Different from Kachin State, where working together is easier through one center, the divided way of the KNU causes different levels of cooperation in its brigades. Various units work with PDFs while other groups follow local plans, which creates bigger problems for making one organized resistance group in Myanmar (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023; ISP Myanmar, 2024). Because the KNU is split, coordination is made difficult for the resistance movement. Inside the villages, individuals interact with the KNLA, PDFs, and the military at the same time. Problematically, this fragmented environment creates confusion and makes the system of ruling and protection from harm hard to manage. Security is reinforced as a fragmented thing through these many groups in Kayin State (Karen Human Rights Group, 2023; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024).

Looking at EAO–PDF relations in Kayin State reveals that groups have different power to organize themselves. Even though the KNU has long-standing institutionalized systems from the past, many PDFs are new and do not have strong command paths. Military strategy is affected by this imbalance which causes the quality of results to be inconsistent (ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute, 2025; ISP Myanmar, 2024). Spreading of military knowledge happens across Myanmar when EAOs and PDFs cooperate. Training which the KNU gives has helped the power of resistance forces so they can do harder working positions against the military regime, in a trend that sees established armed groups help to build the new resistance movements (ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute, 2025; Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023).

#### **4.2.4 Governance and Sovereignty**

Examples from Kayin State show how the system of ruling and sovereignty changes when there is a civil war. Administrative systems are operated by the KNU where they have power to act as an alternative for state institutions including educational institution services, medical professional services, and ways to collect tax (Brenner, 2019; South & Dean, 2018; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024). Since the 2021

coup, these ruling systems grew in areas where the central state became weak. Meanwhile, governance in Kayin State stays uneven due to internal divisions within the KNU. Varying levels of power for ruling are seen across different lands because of these multiple armed actors (ISP Myanmar, 2024; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024). Sovereignty is contested in Kayin State because the military, KNU, PDFs, and local groups share authority. A hybrid political order exists which includes overlapping systems of ruling, as different groups make competing claims for being the legal ruler (South & Dean, 2018; ISP Myanmar, 2024). Civilians feel the system of ruling in a divided way according to what the Karen Human Rights Group says. Since educational institution services or medical professional services depends on the group that controls the land. Governance structures are often broken by military operations which make things unstable (Karen Human Rights Group, 2021; 2023). Being a legal ruler in Kayin State comes from giving services and protection from harm to the people, so that the KNU gets support through its system of ruling while the military uses force. Authority of the military is weakened in areas where there is fighting (Aung, 2025; South & Dean, 2018).

The connection between authority and governmental power is a central nexus of the system of ruling in Kayin State. The KNU stays legitimate in the eyes of the community through the provision of services where the state is gone, while legitimacy is undermined when the military uses violence even if they say they are in control (Karen Human Rights Group, 2021; South & Dean, 2018). Governance within Kayin is not the same across the landscape. Due to overlapping governance systems where multiple actors are present, civilians must move between different authorities. Lack of clarity is created by these conditions and inconsistent access to justice results from this situation, as the complexity of governance is high in fragmented conflict environments (ISP Myanmar, 2024; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024).

#### **4.2.5 Implications for Territorial Integrity**

Significant results for the long-term territorial integrity of Myanmar emerge from developments within Kayin State, the fragmented territorial control might predate patterns of decentralized authority and potential federal restructuring (Asia Pacific

Foundation of Canada, 2023; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024). Concerns about long-term instability are raised by internal fragmentation within resistance movements, since the presence of many actors with different goals makes the creation of unified governance structures difficult (ISP Myanmar, 2024; Kirsch & Flint, 2011). Bringing back the power of the central state in the future becomes increasingly hard because fragmented governance systems are solidifying. These arrangements may stay for a long time when different actors manage territories separately (Kirsch & Flint, 2011). It is observed by scholars that these systems are strengthening. Extreme impacts on human well-being like displacement and loss of working positions are caused by the ongoing conflict (Karen Human Rights Group, 2021; 2023). Territorial fragmentation is reinforced by these factors because a lack of safety remains high, and they increase instability. Bringing back the power of the central state after the conflict stops is made difficult by the long-term solidifying of fragmented authority, as governance systems are likely to stay even when the fighting ends (Kirsch & Flint, 2011). Broader political outcomes are influenced by internal fragmentation within resistance movements as shown by the Kayin situation. A lack of unified structure within the KNU and its brigades complicates efforts to reach agreements on federal reforms (Asia Pacific Foundation of Canada, 2023; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024).

#### **4.2.6 Regional Summary**

Patterns of fragmentation and contested sovereignty in southeastern Myanmar were made stronger by the 2021 coup. Kayin contains a complex system of territorial control which involves many actors, unlike Kachin State where authority is centralized. This region is very different, since resistance dynamics are shaped by the ethnic armed organizations like the KNU when they cooperate with PDFs. A fluid contested political environment is created by internal divisions even though governance capacity is uneven, and these divisions matter. Conflict with the military and internal dynamics within resistance movements drive territorial fragmentation in the Kayin case. These factors provide insights into the difficulties of achieving stability, so that political cohesion is hard to reach. Territorial fragmentation is shaped by internal dynamics within resistance movements in the Kayin region. A fluid and unstable political

environment is caused by the presence of multiple actors while divisions remain, making long-term stability difficult to achieve in Myanmar.

## **4.3 Rakhine**

### **4.3.1 Background of the region**

Rakhine State has transformed into a highly important zone during the struggle after the year 2021 in Myanmar. Because this geographical area sits on the western coast near the border of Bangladesh, the location has witnessed a very long armed struggle between the armed forces of Myanmar and the Arakan Army (AA), which serves as the military branch of the United League of Arakan (ULA). Importantly, the reasons for the fighting in Rakhine State are connected to a long history of ethnic problems and political distance from the center (Brenner, 2019; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024). While resistance groups in other places started mostly after the power seizure, the situation in Rakhine State is different. This specific armed struggle is fueled by old grievances that existed before the current national crisis.

Before the power seizure in 2021, the Arakan Army was already a very strong fighting group that fought fundamental battles against the national armed forces from 2018 until 2020. Although a short peace agreement stopped the shooting before the power seizure, the strained relations between the groups were never fixed. The takeover by the armed forces in February 2021 gave the Arakan Army new chances to grow its power when the central government became weak and had to fight in many different areas at the same time (ACLED, 2024; ISP Myanmar, 2025). The weakening of the state allowed the Arakan Army to move into new spaces. Rakhine State is different from places like Sagaing because the Arakan Army works as a very organized group with a clear political plan. This strength in the organization has helped the Arakan Army move away from small hit-and-run attacks and toward a more official way of holding the land. Overall, Rakhine State is a primary example of how a fighting group can become a governing body when the central state loses its grip, showing how authority moves from the hands of the government to the hands of local forces.

#### **4.3.2 Territorial Control After the 2021 Coup**

Control over the land in Rakhine State moved toward the Arakan Army after the power seizure in 2021. While the national armed forces kept their hold on the big towns and offices at first, the Arakan Army expanded its activities when the fighting became heavy again at the end of 2023. By the start of 2024, many towns and important roads were captured by the Arakan Army (ACLED, 2024; ISP Myanmar, 2025). This movement changed the map of the geographical area completely. The ability of the Arakan Army to break the power of the armed forces in the middle of Rakhine State was a sizable change. Many observers report that the Arakan Army hit the main military bases very hard, and these bases were once the symbols of state power (Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024). These victories allowed the Arakan Army to create its own rules in the countryside and smaller towns. Consequently, the influence of the national government is now only seen in a few strong locations. The way the Arakan Army holds the land is different from Sagaing or Kayin because the control in those areas is always breaking and changing. In Rakhine State, the Arakan Army has shown that it can keep the land and not just fight for it. This physical authority is shown through the building of roadblocks and the management of how people move and trade (ISP Myanmar, 2025), and the group creates its own laws to manage the daily life of the local inhabitants.

Still, the control over Rakhine State is not hundred percent finished. The national armed forces still hold some important areas, especially in the big urban centers and near the main transport paths. However, the weight of power has moved a lot, and the Arakan Army is now the strongest actor in most of the geographical area. This change proves that the power of the central state has dried up in Rakhine State since the power seizure.

#### **4.3.3 Role of EAOs and PDFs**

The Arakan Army is the main force that decides the fighting and the politics in Rakhine State. Unlike the small and scattered groups seen in Sagaing, it follows a single leader and keeps a high level of order. This order allows the Arakan Army to plan large operations and stay in the fight for a long time (Brenner, 2019; ACLED, 2024). Because the group is united, its actions are very effective against the national armed forces. A

strategic plan is used to grow its military power and its political name at the same time. Besides taking the land, the group works to make its bond with the local inhabitants stronger. Providing safety and managing the local market are some of the ways the Arakan Army works in the areas it holds (ISP Myanmar, 2025). Thanks to these features, it is seen more as a government than just a group of fighters, and its independence is another thing that differentiates it from other groups. While there is some talking between different groups that hate the military, the Arakan Army follows its own path to take control of Rakhine State, focused on its own regional goals, a choice that separates it from groups in Sagaing that need to work with others to survive (Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024). The growing strength of the Arakan Army has changed the whole picture of the struggle in Myanmar. Its success in holding the land shows that a well-organized group can beat the national armed forces when the local situation is good, and the model used by the Arakan Army could be studied by other groups in the country.

#### **4.3.4 Governance and Sovereignty at the Subnational Level**

The creation of management systems by the Arakan Army and the United League of Arakan is a very important step in Rakhine State. In the areas where the national armed forces are gone, the Arakan Army has started doing the work of a government, such as solving fights between people and managing the money (ISP Myanmar, 2025). These actions show that the state is no longer the only one in charge. This way of managing the land is called contested sovereignty because more than one group says they are the boss. In Rakhine State, the strong position of the Arakan Army has created a system that is more solid than in other geographical areas. Local offices are operated by the group to make sure that the rules are followed in the lands they hold (South & Dean, 2018). It is believed by many that these systems are replacing the old state structures.

The support for the Arakan Army grows when the group provides services to the local inhabitants. By keeping the peace and helping the people, the group shows that it is a better choice than the central government. This is very important, since the national

military is often seen as a cause of pain instead of a source of law. However, the management by the Arakan Army has some problems too. The control is not complete, and the group is still learning how to run a government. Also, because the national armed forces still hold some parts, there are two different systems of law, and the local inhabitants must follow different rules depending on where they are. Even with these troubles, the work of the Arakan Army is a very advanced example of how a group can run a territory in Myanmar.

The way the national military tries to stop the Arakan Army is another part of the story in Rakhine State. Historically, the armed forces of Myanmar used a plan of defending their spots and attacking specific targets. But after the 2021 power seizure, the national military is being hit from all sides, so it cannot put all its strength into Rakhine State. This situation gave the Arakan Army a chance to push the government forces out (ACLED, 2024; ISP Myanmar, 2025).

In Sagaing, the national military uses many airplanes to drop bombs and burn villages to stop the resistance, but this does not work well in Rakhine State. The Arakan Army has a better structure and deep support from the local inhabitants, so it can survive the attacks and keep the towns it took. Arguably, the success of a group depends on how well the local inhabitants help the fighters against state violence (Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024). The Arakan Army is very good at mixing the fighting with political plans. Instead of just using guns, the group builds schools and offices to help the local inhabitants. This double method makes the Arakan Army stronger and gives it more respect. Unlike the messy groups in other regions, the centralized way the Arakan Army works allows it to coordinate the fighting and the governance together (Brenner, 2019; ISP Myanmar, 2025). The help from the local inhabitants is a very large reason why the Arakan Army is winning. Support from the people gives the group many resources, such as news about the enemy and new young people to join the fight. In the areas where the Arakan Army is seen as the real leader, the communities help the administration gladly. This bond between the armed group and the people makes the control over the land very strong (South & Dean, 2018).

The situation in Rakhine State also shows that territorial control is changing. While the Arakan Army is the real boss on the ground, the rest of the world does not recognize it officially. This creates a split where the official government is on paper, but

a non-state actor is the real power, and these kinds of situations change how we think about what a country is during a civil war (Kirsch & Flint, 2011). The money part of the struggle is also very significant for the Arakan Army. Holding the trade roads and the natural wealth of the land gives the group the money it needs to keep fighting and running the offices. In Rakhine State, having the coast and the border for trade makes the control of the land very valuable. These economic factors help the Arakan Army stay powerful for a long time (ISP Myanmar, 2025). Even with these gains, nobody knows for sure what will happen next in Rakhine State. The national armed forces can still use their airplanes to bomb the areas held by the Arakan Army. Also, the whole political situation in Myanmar is shaking, and changes in the big cities could change the fight in the geographical area, while the struggle is still moving and changing every day (ACLED, 2024). The power of the Arakan Army makes people ask about the future of the whole country. While the local management brings some peace, it might also make the gap between the different regions wider. Having a strong group in charge could lead to the people asking for their own country or a special kind of freedom. This will make the talks about the future of Myanmar very difficult (Brenner, 2019). Overall, Rakhine State shows that power, management, and the support of the people are all tied together. The ability of the Arakan Army to be strong in both fighting and governance makes it very different from other actors. Because the national military is still fighting and the future is not clear, Rakhine State remains a place where the rules are being rewritten.

#### **4.3.5 Implications for Territorial Integrity**

The events in Rakhine State carry a heavy meaning for the unity of Myanmar as a whole country. The way the Arakan Army has gathered power makes people think about the geographical area becoming self-governed or even splitting away. While it is hard to become a separate country right now, the fact that a strong group is running itself challenges the idea of one single state (Brenner, 2019; ACLED, 2024). Rakhine State proves that when a country breaks into pieces, it does not always mean there is no order. Instead, a new system of management can be born that is quite stable. This is not like Sagaing, where the breaking of power leads to a lot of confusion because there is no single leader. In Rakhine State, the Arakan Army provides a clear path for the people.

The rise of strong local groups will make it very hard to put Myanmar back together in the future. When the time comes to talk about a new government, the different levels of control in each geographical area will change the conversation. In this story, Rakhine State is a successful model of local rule, but it is also an important test for the unity of the nation.

#### **4.3.6 Regional Summary**

Rakhine State is a very clear example of how an armed struggle can turn into a real government on the ground. Since the power seizure in 2021, the Arakan Army has grown its fighting and its hold on the land while building its own offices (ACLED, 2024; ISP Myanmar, 2025). Compared to Kachin or Kayin, where the control is still in many small pieces, Rakhine State shows a much more unified power under the Arakan Army (Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024). It is widely believed that this geographical area has moved the furthest away from the control of the central state. Recognizing this difference is significant because Myanmar's conflict is not just about the country breaking into pieces and also shows new administrative structures appearing. While the national governing body becomes weak, long-lasting ways to control the territory and political power are created by the Arakan Army. Rakhine provides an illustrative case by demonstrating how regional influence grows even though the national government is collapsing and the internal armed struggle continues.

### **4.4 Sagaing**

#### **4.4.1 Background of the Region**

Sagaing Region sits in the central part of the nation and became the location for armed struggle against the armed state forces after the 2021 coup. This land was previously held under the firm grip of the administrative authority unlike Kachin or Rakhine which are located at the edges of the nation and have a long history of fighting. While Sagaing Region did not have many old fights between ethnic groups, the situation changed very fast because the armed state forces used physical aggression

against people in the public demonstrations. This change happened when private individuals created People's Defence Forces (PDFs) (ACLED, 2024; BAMF, 2024). This transformation was triggered by the military when they attacked the protesters. A significant movement in how the armed struggle works in Myanmar is represented by this change. While groups from ethnic backgrounds usually lead the fighting in the edge regions, Sagaing Region shows an armed struggle that began after the coup and is led by local inhabitants instead of old organizations. In this way, hundreds of local defense groups were established in the rural settlements and towns of Sagaing Region (BAMF, 2024). These groups have different levels of working together even though they are organized at the local level.

Sagaing Region quickly turned into anti-military resistance. Because the peaceful public demonstrations were stopped with weapons, many private individuals started an armed struggle which caused the whole area to become full of weapons and soldiers. This movement follows a path where the fighting moved from the ethnic areas into the central heart of the nation (ACLED, 2024). Sagaing Region is part of this expansion into the middle of the country and is different from the other regions covered in this thesis. While Kachin and Rakhine are shaped by old struggles, Sagaing Region is a new example, given how the armed struggle there does not have one central leader. Understanding how the land is being divided is made possible by looking at this case which is a critical example for studying territorial fragmentation.

#### **4.4.2 Territorial Control After the 2021 Coup**

The 2021 coup changed territorial control of Sagaing Region and created a fragmented environment for the armed struggle. It is stated that fighting with weapons has happened in many towns (ISP Myanmar, 2024). Sagaing Region is now one of the places most marked by the armed struggle in the nation. This situation was caused by the important change in how the territory is managed. Authority over the territory is shared among many different groups that are fighting. While one group has taken most of the power in Rakhine, the power in Sagaing is spread out. PDFs and groups from the rural settlements work in the countryside even though the armed state forces keep control of the major cities and the roads. This creates a situation where the land is not

stable and the lines of the fighting are always moving (ACLED, 2024; ISP Myanmar, 2024).

Large pieces of land were sometimes taken by the people who fought against the administrative authority. For example, groups against the military took the town of Kawlin for a short time which was an important win. Even though they won, keeping the land is hard when the armed state forces attack them back using planes from the sky (AP News, 2023). These victories are often held for a short time. The control of the land is made more unstable because the armed state forces burn the buildings and the fields, to the point that many rural settlements were burned in Sagaing Region (Myanmar Witness, 2024). People were forced to leave their homes after these actions. The lives of private individuals are ruined by these attacks which makes it hard for any leader to have a stable system of ruling. Sagaing Region is seen as a place where the control is always changing and disputed rather than being solid. Territory is held only for a short time and power is always being discussed again between the groups that are in competition, so that the authority in Sagaing Region is constantly renegotiated.

Physical aggression is used by the armed state forces to show they are the masters of Sagaing Region. Instead of trying to stay in the rural areas all the time, the armed state forces use attacks to punish the people by dropping bombs and burning houses to make the resistance weak. This is likely done to stop private individuals from helping the PDFs. Sagaing Region has seen many fires since rural settlements were destroyed by the armed state forces as part of their operations (Myanmar Witness, 2024). This specific plan shows a movement away from traditional land management toward a method called denial-based control, as the military wants to stop resistance groups from gathering power instead of keeping direct administrative oversight over the people. Because the military fails to hold ground, huge areas of Sagaing remain in a state where authority is shared or not clear (ACLED, 2024; ISP Myanmar, 2024). A condition of fragmented power is maintained by the military when they cannot secure full victory, which leaves the inhabitants in a state of confusion. These repetitive patterns of land possession and dispossession in Sagaing make the territorial division even stronger as the months pass. Resistance forces sometimes take over small towns or rural settlements for a short time, but these areas are often lost when military attacks occur once again. This constant changing of hands stops the creation of much-needed

lasting administrative structures. Territorial authority in this geographic area is made unstable by the frequent movement of frontlines, even though the resistance tries to hold the ground for a long time (AP News, 2023; ACLED, 2024).

#### **4.4.3 Role of EAOs and PDFs**

The People's Defence Forces (PDFs) are the primary armed actors within Sagaing after they appeared following the government takeover. Many observers say that PDFs are very different from old ethnic armed organizations because they are not organized under one central head. While these resistance groups vary in their supply of tools and their working position capacity, they remain active across the whole region (BAMF, 2024). A decentralized structure is adopted by these groups so that they can survive against the military. Various PDFs perform their duties alone at the neighborhood level, while other groups talk with the National Unity Government (NUG). This way, training and help are given to some PDFs by existing ethnic armed organizations like the Kachin Independence Army (ACLED, 2024). This situation builds a complicated web of alliances and ties rather than a single chain of command. Because no single leader exists for everyone, the network stays flexible and adapts to the war. Both power and frailty are found in the scattered nature of PDFs. Resistance is allowed to grow across the whole province when groups operate in small parts, which makes it hard for the military to destroy the opposition completely. On the other hand, this layout creates coordination problems between the units. Division within the resistance movement is often caused by the lack of a central office, even though the goal remains the same.

Evidence shows that internal disagreements and racing for power between different resistance groups have started in some areas, hurting how well the groups fight against the enemy during battles. Complicated problems arise when the resistance groups fail to make one plan against the military (AP News, 2024). A unified strategy is made difficult to achieve by these small internal fights that occur over resources. The PDFs have shown that their fighting ability is growing even though they face many hurdles. Ambushes are conducted by these fighters, and they have also entered military bases while working with other resistance members. It is often argued that these events

show the rising strength of scattered resistance forces in Myanmar (ACLED, 2024). Sagaing serves as a place where the fight is pushed by the gathering of the general population instead of central ethnic groups.

The way PDFs in Sagaing change their shape over time is another vital part of their story. Many PDFs were organized poorly at the start and did not have official rules for leadership or training. Over time, some groups have become more organized as the war continues, which helps them build better paths for orders. This slow growth of a formal educational institution for fighting is an attempt to fix the problems of having no center (BAMF, 2024; ACLED, 2024). Order is being sought by these groups through better rules and discipline. Unbalanced power levels within the resistance movement are created by the differences in money and tools between different PDFs. Some groups have better gear and more knowledge when they receive help from ethnic armed organizations, which gives them more strength, other groups have very few resources and struggle to survive. This uneven growth makes the movement stay split, which stops the resistance from being as strong as possible (ISP Myanmar, 2024).

The bond between PDFs and the people living in the villages is a very important thing for keeping the fight alive. Logistic support, secrets about the enemy, and safe houses are provided to resistance groups by the regular citizens in many areas. Many researchers believe that this close tie between the people and the fighters makes Sagaing different from other regions. The shape of the war is changed when the whole society joins the struggle together (Myanmar Witness, 2024). One extra layer of administrative control within Sagaing includes the birth of unofficial and mixed management frameworks. Because central power remains absent, local neighborhoods and fighting units have created temporary methods to oversee the protection of people, settle arguments between neighbors, and deliver necessary public assistance. These frameworks frequently unite old-style community headman roles with fresh styles of opposition management (ISP Myanmar, 2024). Protection of people is overseen by these temporary methods which local neighborhoods created.

These management frameworks stay weak and lean heavily on what happens on the ground. When the fighting forces conduct many operations, the administrative frameworks often fall apart completely, so that regular people find themselves without any necessary public assistance. Management frameworks are often broken by intense

fighting, which reveals how easily decentralized management frameworks can be damaged when fighting becomes heavy (Myanmar Witness, 2024). Actually, fighting units struggle to change from soldiers into official ruling bodies, as the administrative ability is missing, and within Sagaing they generally do not possess the organizational experience that is needed to keep management going for a long time, which is different from older groups like the Kachin Independence Organization or the Arakan Army. Sovereignty is divided in the region because of this lack of experience, and this situation makes the fragmented nature of power in the area even stronger (Brenner, 2019; ISP Myanmar, 2024).

#### **4.4.4 Governance and Sovereignty at the Subnational Level**

Management inside Sagaing Region is split into many pieces and shows how the fighting is spread out, lacking one strong ruler that can manage large geographic land areas, which is different from Rakhine where the Arakan Army has built organized management frameworks. Management is split into many pieces because no single group holds total power, within frameworks are often unofficial and lack organizational strength even though local fighting units and neighborhood groups have tried to build basic management tasks where the opposition holds power. These tasks include local rule, protection of people, and fixing arguments between neighbors (ISP Myanmar, 2024). Basic management tasks are tried by local fighting units to help their communities; with the idea that fought-over sovereignty brings trouble for regular people inside Sagaing. Power is shared among many players, such as the army, fighting units, and local armed groups, which leads to management frameworks that sit on top of each other. This means regular people must choose which official ruling bodies to follow based on what is happening in their town.

Power is shared among many players in a way that creates confusion while continuous fighting makes management even weaker. Army attacks often hit areas where the opposition rules, which stops management work and causes chaos. Official papers show that people are forced to leave their homes and villages are burned, which stops the fighting units from giving steady management (Myanmar Witness, 2024; AP News, 2024). Villages are burned during army attacks so that administrative work cannot

continue, while some people try to make the fighting units work together better by creating regional groups. Even though these plans exist, they stay small and have not created one strong management framework. Regional groups are created to help units work together, but the results remain limited. Overall, management is spread out and shaky when describing the situation in Sagaing, which matches the broken power in the area, which reflects the wider trouble in the region.

#### **4.4.5 Implications for Territorial Integrity**

The area is bound to remain in turmoil for a long time because of the fragmented nature of local authority. The events happening in Sagaing Region carry weight for the long-term wholeness of Myanmar. The wholeness of Myanmar is impacted by events in Sagaing Region while many armed groups continue to grow, being split apart without one clear center. This is different from Rakhine where gathered land might help the region rule itself. One management framework is hard to create due to the presence of many armed groups with different goals. Negotiating a peaceful agreement is also made difficult by this fragmentation. Fixing the country after the fighting ends will be hard because of this split. Even if the army rulers lose power, bringing all the spread-out fighting units into one political group would be a hard and messy task. Spread-out units are hard to bring into one group since they have functioned alone for a long time, and Sagaing shows how regular people can fight against a harsh ruler. The growth of fighting units shows a significant change in the politics of Myanmar, where regular people are the main ones deciding how the fighting goes. Politics are changed by the growth of fighting units which come from the community.

#### **4.4.6 Regional Summary**

Within the current research, Sagaing Region stands as the most fragmented and shaky example. The rapid growth of scattered People's Defence Forces since the 2021 military coup changed Sagaing Region into a central point of broad opposition. Because territorial control is frequently fought over by various groups, the situation remains very changing (ACLED, 2024; ISP Myanmar, 2025). When compared to Kachin and

Rakhine, where joined groups built steady systems of ruling, Sagaing Region is marked by the lack of a strong leader who can join power together across the land. The difference between these areas carries weight: the way land is split shows how different results come from different levels of group ability. The scattered nature of resistance groups in Sagaing Region allows for broad fighting against the soldiers while the growth of steady ruling systems is slowed down. Low group ability is shown to lead to these weak ruling structures when Sagaing Region is measured against other places (BAMF, 2024). This situation points to the difficulties of changing scattered fighting into lasting territorial control. While the central government is weakened by the actions of this area, Sagaing Region also shows the problems that fragmented administrations have in creating long-term political peace. Sagaing Region is a very important example for looking at the link between fighting, splitting, and ruling in the time after the coup in Myanmar.

## **5 DIRECT COMPARISON OF THE FOUR REGIONS**

The four regions analyzed in this thesis – Kachin, Kayin, Rakhine, and Sagaing – show specific but linked ways of holding land and managing power after the coup in Myanmar. Although every region demonstrates that the central military state became weak after the 2021 coup, the regions are very different in how power is built and kept at the local level. A comparison of these areas shows changes in how conflict works and how sovereignty is changing across Myanmar. The transformation of sovereignty is driven by local armed actors.

Centralization of armed actors is a major point when comparing these regions. Inside Kachin and Rakhine, authority stays mostly inside strong ethnic groups. Within Kachin, the Kachin Independence Organization (KIO) and its armed wing, the Kachin Independence Army (KIA), have stayed for a long time with clear rules and leadership. This long history helped the KIO keep power over land even after the coup happened (Brenner, 2019; ACLED, 2024). In the same way, the Arakan Army (AA) became the strongest group in Rakhine by building its military and its rule. The power of the Arakan Army was strengthened because the group changed from a small fighting force into an organization capable of managing territory (Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024; ISP

Myanmar, 2025). Kayin and Sagaing show more broken ways of organizing fighters. Even though the Karen National Union (KNU) is still a central player in Kayin, the KNU works with many small groups and local resistance organizations, a situation which creates a map where many leaders co-exist. In contrast, Sagaing is the most fragmented region due to the presence of many People's Defence Forces (PDFs) which work there without much help from each other. These groups do not have one leader, and they depend on local people, so the fighting environment is very split (BAMF, 2024; ACLED, 2024). This lack of one leader has strong repercussions over territorial control.

Stability of territorial control is another thing to compare. Rakhine is the region where control is most solid. Since the end of 2023, the Arakan Army has taken over big towns and main roads, which allowed the group to have strong power over the land (ACLED, 2024; ISP Myanmar, 2025). This strong control is very different from Sagaing, where who holds the land changes all the time. In Sagaing, fighters might take a village for a short time, but the military often attacks to take it, and no single group can keep large areas for a long time in Sagaing. Kachin stays in the middle of these two types. The KIA holds a lot of land near the borders, but the military still fights them for it. While Kachin is more stable than Sagaing or Kayin, the power over land is not complete. At the same time, Kayin is defined by zones that overlap and are broken. Different groups work in different spots, and the way they help or fight each other can change quickly (Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024). These variations show that the geography of how Myanmar is uneven is not the same everywhere.

Building systems and rules for governing are also different in these regions. In Kachin and Rakhine, the fighters created organized systems for the people. For a long time, the KIO has kept offices for collecting taxes, teaching in educational institutions, and managing local life. Likewise, the Arakan Army grew its ability to rule by making offices and using its power over the people who live there (ISP Myanmar, 2025). These systems help the groups look legitimate and help them keep their land. Managing the people in Kayin is not as unified. Although the KNU has offices in some spots, these rules are not the same everywhere because too many groups are present. Sagaing has the least amount of system building. Rule in Sagaing is often just local people helping each other through decentralized fights. While local groups might offer safety, these groups

usually do not have the power to make lasting systems for governance (BAMF, 2024). In sum, the way fighters are organized changes how local systems grow.

Even with these differences, the four areas are linked together. A big part of the comparison is how the fighters talk to each other across the regions. One important link is the way ethnic groups and People's Defence Forces work together. In Sagaing, many PDFs got guns and training from groups like the Kachin Independence Army. This shows that the old fighting groups on the borders are helping the new groups in the center of Myanmar (ACLED, 2024; ISP Myanmar, 2025). Similar things happen in Kayin where the KNU and new fighters work together to fight the military. These links between regions show that the Myanmar conflict is more connected now because alliances go past just one area, and these relationships are based on needs and plans rather than deep rules. Problems with political goals or ethnic history can stop groups from working perfectly together. Alliances are the main way to understand how the fighting moves. When ethnic groups and PDFs work together, the pressure on the military leaders grows. Joint fighting and sharing information have made the resistance more effective in many spots, but these alliances change depending on the situation. Disagreements between groups can make the cooperation weak when local interests are not the same (ACLED, 2024). Rakhine is different when we look at how groups work together. The Arakan Army mostly works by itself and cares more about holding its own land than helping PDFs. This choice shows that the group is strong and has its own goals. In contrast, the fragmented areas like Kayin and Sagaing need groups to help each other to keep fighting. The way groups join together depends on how much power they have in their own region.

How the military acts also change what happens to the land. The military uses different plans in each area, which changes who is in charge. In Sagaing, the military uses planes to bomb and destroy villages because they want to stop the resistance from having land. This plan makes the region more fractured. But in Rakhine, the military cannot stop the Arakan Army from growing, so the military lost a lot of territory. These differences show that military plans and local facts work together to change the conflict (Myanmar Witness, 2024).

Comparing these regions allows for thinking about what happens if Myanmar keeps breaking. One path is that local systems of governance become very strong. In

this situation, large groups like the Arakan Army or the KIO could keep stable land and build real governments. These areas might work like independent zones that do not listen to a central leader, as regions that could split up in the future. Sagaing might stay very messy because it does not have one leader. If the resistance stays split, the fighting will last a long time and systems will not grow. Kayin might stay in the middle where groups talk a little but remain divided. Altogether, this unequal growth will make the political map of Myanmar very strange. Another possibility is a new federal system where regions get to rule themselves. However, the different levels of power and offices in each area might make this change hard. Strong groups will want more power, but the different areas might struggle to have a clear voice, an imbalance that could cause fights during future talks. Finally, a darker path is that the breaking continues without an end. In this case, Myanmar might become a collection of many fighting leaders where no one rules the whole country. Such a situation would be bad for the economy and safety. Because many armed actors will stay, fixing the state will be very difficult. This comparison shows that the way the central power is getting weak means Myanmar is changing fundamentally. This is not just a state falling; it is a way that new power is being built in the regions. How this story ends might depend upon how groups talk and fight.

Overall, looking at Kachin, Kayin, Rakhine, and Sagaing shows that the conflict in Myanmar is not the same everywhere. The conflict shows a pattern of land breaking that is shaped by how fighters are organized and how they rule. At the same time, the links between these areas show that the conflict is joined together. Understanding these things is necessary for seeing if Myanmar will remain fragmented or find a new way to be a country. These regional differences bring up questions about what happens if the central government disappears. The current patterns suggest the country would not just have chaos everywhere. Instead, Myanmar would break into different political zones, each with its own path, based on the strength of local groups, the national military and its systems. In places like Rakhine, the Arakan Army already has a lot of land and rules. If the central state falls, a quasi-state could be built there. The AA has shown it can collect money and keep order, which means it can become a real government: even if the world does not call it a country, it would be a stable place that rules itself (ACLED, 2024; ISP Myanmar, 2025). Kachin might follow a similar path but with more trouble.

The Kachin Independence Organization has offices and land, so a weak central state makes the KIO stronger. But because the military is still in some spots in Kachin, the territory is still marked by fighting, so that it would likely be an autonomous region but not fully unified (Brenner, 2019; Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024). Sagaing would likely have a different result, since the local fighters are not joined under one leader, so that a state collapse could lead to more breaking. Without one strong group to manage the region, the land might stay divided among many small groups and lead to more instability, because coordination is very hard (ACLED, 2024; BAMF, 2024). Kayin would be in the middle, with the Karen National Union providing some order, and with a plurality of groups and changing allegiances making things complex. If the state falls, Kayin could become a system where many leaders control different spots but talk to each other. This would not be one unified system, but it could bring some peace through deals between the groups (Myanmar Peace Monitor, 2024).

Relationships between different areas are a major detail in this situation. Existing cooperation between ethnic armed organizations and People's Defence Forces suggests that cross-regional networks have a big responsibility in making the results. For instance, more powerful actors such as the Kachin Independence Army could go on helping resistance groups in more fragmented geographic zones, which changes the power balance outside their own lands. Even though these groups work together, a fully joined political system is hard to be made as differences in regional interests and priorities remain large (ISP Myanmar, 2025). These connections will be the main thing to watch for the future. If the Myanmar state breaks down completely, the result will probably be observed as a very unequal political landscape. This environment has a mix of strong regional authorities, zones with some freedom, and areas with many fights. Arguably, the country will show many types of local governance happening at the same time instead of just one result. This situation shows that regional variation is very significant for the future of Myanmar. Because these deep roots in territorial control and institutional capacity exist, any long-term political solution must think about them.

## 6 CONCLUSION

The research looked at how territorial control, governing, and fighting groups work in four important areas of Myanmar which are Kachin, Kayin, Rakhine, and Sagaing after the 2021 military coup. By comparing these regions, the systematic investigation showed that while all areas show the central state getting weak, the way power is handled at the local level is very different. Myanmar is a complicated and uneven country where territorial fragmentation is shaped by local life, old systems, and what armed actors can do. Instead of one single way of falling apart, the country takes many different shapes depending on which region we are discussing. The territorial control in Myanmar changed in many ways at once. In Kachin, old ethnic armed organizations like the Kachin Independence Organization kept stable systems of governance and territorial control. In Rakhine, the Arakan Army changed to be more like a quasi-state by controlling land and making administrative structures. Kayin is a more fragmented region, as many armed groups work there. Sagaing is the most spread-out example because locally organized People's Defence forces make very fast-changing and shaky patterns of control. These differences show that regional variation is necessary for knowing the Myanmar conflict after the coup.

This research is significant because it links academic ideas of land breaking with real evidence of fighting in Myanmar. By using ideas like contested sovereignty and civil war fragmentation for these regional cases, the research creates a better picture of how state power is changing, since state weakening does not always lead to chaos but can make new forms of governance appear. This thought is very significant for knowing how political power changes when central control goes down. A clearer understanding of this change is provided by this academic examination. An important part of this thesis is the way it compares geographic zones. The academic examination shows the different regional dynamics of the Myanmar civil war by looking at four different areas with their own fighting styles. This method shows how different forms of territorial control and governing grow in different spaces instead of looking at the fight as one single national event. Organizational structure, local alliances, and history change the results of the fight. This comparative view makes the whole academic examination stronger and gives a better understanding of the Myanmar political change.

There are some limitations in this academic examination that people should know. First, the work uses mostly indirect informational documents like reports and academic books. Even though these papers are of notable importance and overall quality, the documents might not see the small local movements or what the people in the fight think. Second, the Myanmar situation changes very fast, which can change how right the observations are over time. Looking at only four geographic zones does not show the broader picture of the Myanmar conflict. Other areas might have different forms of governance that this academic examination does not talk about. While these restricted boundaries exist, future research is very significant, especially work in the field that gives better views of local conflict life. One way for more research is talking to individuals who are part of the fight. Specifically, the academic examination would be better with views from people in the People's Defence Forces (PDFs). Talking to these members could give better thoughts about how people join, how they organize locally, and how they work with other armed groups. This kind of qualitative evidence would help the other sources by showing how territorial control and governance feel at the local level. However, this research needs careful thinking about ethics, like keeping names secret and safety, because the conflict is very sensitive.

This thesis showed that the Myanmar conflict after the coup is a crisis of state power and also a time of political change. The growth of different territorial control forms, from strong systems in Kachin and Rakhine to broken structures in Kayin and Sagaing, means the future will be made by these changing regional ways. Whether Myanmar goes toward a federal system or stays broken depends on how these actors talk and how the broader confrontation goes. This academic paper shows that civil war is a process of breakdown and also one of change. By looking at territorial control, governance, and regional variations, the research gives a way to understand how new political truths appear when states get weak. These findings help the understanding of the Myanmar conflict and give a base for more research on broken states.

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